SOLID, LIQUID, AND GAS

Synopsis

Imagine if the host of a children's show had a mental breakdown on national television and then had to get their life back together while teaching science to an audience who no longer believes in science. *Solid, Liquid, and Gas* is a thirty-minute comedy-drama tv series that explores the miserable reality of adulthood through the whimsical perspective of children's educational programming.

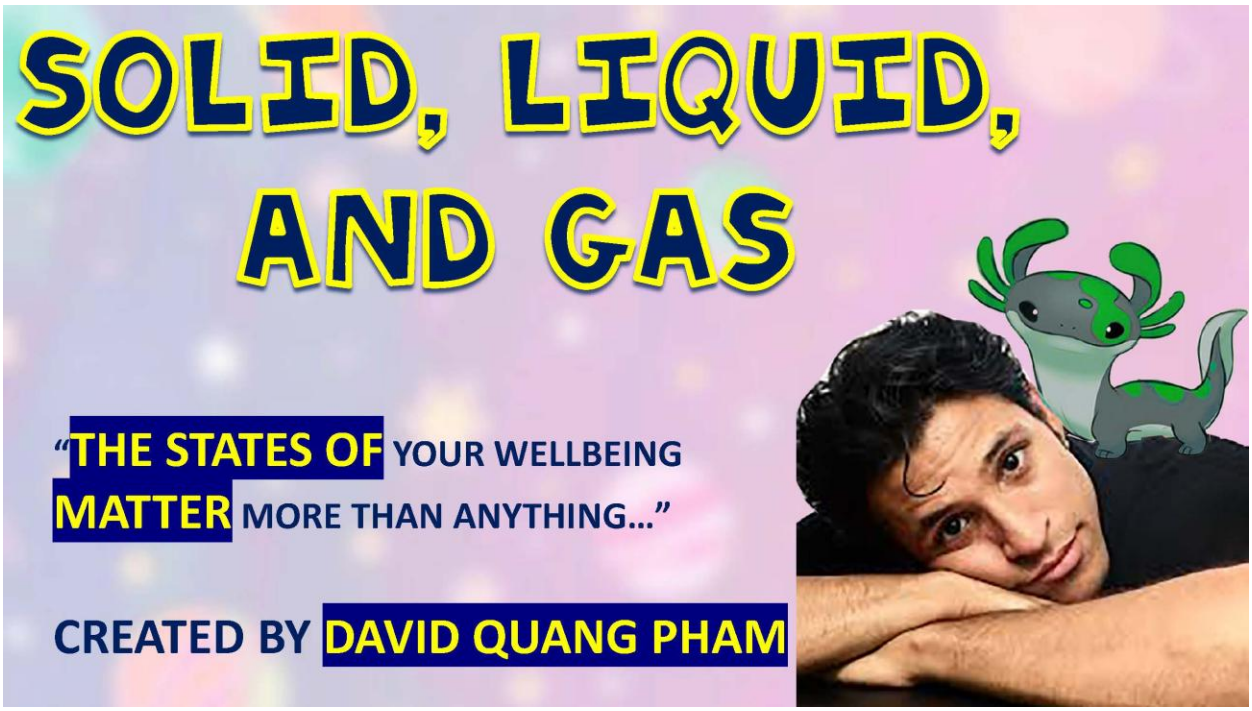
Trini "Ray" Reyes is a 29-year-old Filipina American educator whose acting career literally went up in flames when she accidentally burned down a theater during a production of *Cat Scouts Live*. Blacklisted and facing eviction, Ray clings to the only thing that ever made her feel safe: the memory of *Stardust*, a cosmic science show from the early 2000s hosted by the charismatic Clay.

When Ray hears that the network is reviving the show as *StarPower!*, she sees it as her last chance at redemption. However, this version is corporate, and led by her academic rival, the poised Ms. Aurora Sterling. Ray manages to win her way into the production, not as the star, but as Aurora's sidekick.

The first season follows Ray as she navigates the surreal divide between the fantastical set of *StarPower!* and her bleak reality. She lives in a cramped apartment with her neurodivergent younger brother, Kwan "Sunshine" Reyes, an astronomy prodigy who is facing his own academic crisis.

As the season progresses, the fourth wall Ray breaks on camera begins to bleed into her real life. She seeks out her childhood hero, Clay, only to find him a recluse living in Brooklyn. Together, this found family of science nerds must navigate hot mics, anti-science internet trolls, and the pressures of being a role model in an unforgiving world.

SOLID, LIQUID, AND GAS



The series uses the states of matter as a metaphor for character growth. Ray begins as gas; invisible and lacking a clear shape. By the finale, after Aurora is suspended for a political statement and Ray is fired for standing by her, she learns to be a plasma of energized light, ready to create a new world on her own terms.

"It's *Blue Clues*! …for adults…" – Carissa Sky

COLD OPEN

EXT. MINIVERSE

The world is framed in a 4:3 aspect ratio. A decorative POP-UP BOOK titled STARDUST cracks open. A ROCKET SHIP with a friendly, animated face pops out from the pages.

CLAY (24), radiating energy in a colorful cosmic vest, appears in the rocket's window and waves enthusiastically.

CLAY
Planets, comets, and galaxies everywhere! It's me, Clay! Have you seen our best friend, Stardust?

STARDUST, an animated, whimsical mudpuppy, soars out from behind a cardboard star and loops around the ship.

STARDUST
(Through yelps and whines)
Twinkle, twinkle, twinkle.

Unseen KIDS answer in unison along with TRINI "RAY" REYES (4).

KIDS (V.O.)
There she is!

RAY (V.O.)
She's right behind you!

Clay ducks back inside.

ROCKET
Come on in, stardusters!

The camera follows Stardust as she dives through the window. Inside, the ship is filled with charming cardboard controls. Clay searches the cabin.

CLAY
Hi! We're so glad you're here!
We're almost ready to land.
Stardust? Stardust?

Stardust giggles and ducks underneath a nearby table. Clay turns to the camera.

CLAY (CONT'D)
Did you see Stardust?

KIDS (V.O.)
Right there! Under the table!

RAY (V.O.)
Are you blind?!

Clay mimics hand-goggles, spotting her with a laugh.

CLAY
Stardust! What world should we visit today?

Clay gestures to the window, where cutouts of a blue, white, and green planet hang against a dark backdrop.

CLAY (CONT'D)
A *BLUE* planet? A *CLUE* we need bathing suits. Do you have one?

Stardust shakes her head no.

CLAY (CONT'D)
Should we land on the white planet? Brrr! Do you have your winter coat?

Stardust shakes her head no. Clay points to the final world.

CLAY (CONT'D)
Then what color is this one?

KIDS (V.O.)
Green!

CLAY
Yellow?

RAY (V.O.)
GREEN FOR CRYING OUT LOUD!

KIDS (V.O.)
GREEN! GREEN! GREEN!

CLAY
Ah! The GREEN planet! Do you have your sunglasses?

Stardust puts on a pair of shades.

Clay breaks into a catchy jingle.

CLAY (CONT'D)
Rocket, take us to the GREEN!
LET'S LAND ON THIS PLANET

INT. REYES LIVING ROOM - DAY (2001)

A square TV plays the show. Ray (4, Filipina American) dances along, in her homemade CARDBOARD ROCKET SHIP COSTUME.

CLAY & RAY
LET'S LAND ON THIS PLANET
I WONDER IF WE'LL CALL IT HOME?

Much like Clay, Ray turns to face her own "camera."

RAY
You my audience, welcome to mine home! I am Trini *Reyes*, friend of Cway, wanna pway?

On the table, a *Stardust* coloring book lies open. Inside, a child's messy coloring fills a page featuring Clay and the show's creators:
- RIVER MATTHEWS (25, Ms. Frizzle-like) with Stardust puppet.
- SCHUYLER "SKYE" PARK (26, Korean, in over their head).
- YASMIN "YLEM" LEM (26, an animated animator).

RAY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
It so fun talkin' to thin air!

MONTAGE - FIVE YEARS LATER

2002

Rain hits the window. Ray (5) sits in the dark, out of her costume. She glances at the camera.

RAY (CONT'D)
It can also be lonely...

On the TV, Clay and Stardust drift in a black hole.

STARDUST
Twinkle, twinkle, twinkle!

CLAY
Don't be scared! The darker it is, the more glitter we can see!

Reassured, Ray pulls her glittery rocket costume back on.

CLAY (CONT'D)
You are not alone!

2003

Ray's baby brother, KWAN, crawls towards the TV screen. Ray (6) sits him down and crowns him an astronaut helmet.

On the TV, Clay shows Stardust how to moonwalk. In the room, Ray helps Kwan take his first steps. He falls face first.

CLAY (CONT'D)
Gravity's the world giving us a hug!

2004

On the TV, Clay and Stardust sled across an icy comet. They pull out smoothies.

CLAY (CONT'D)
It's not just a rock, stardusters.
We're sledding on a smoothie comet!
Made of water, ice, *dust*, and sugar-

Ray (7) and Kwan (2) share a smoothie before wincing hard.

CLAY & RAY & KWAN
Brain freeze!

STARDUST
Twinkle, twinkle, twinkle!

2005

Ray (8) performs a sock puppet show for Kwan (3) using puppets she made to look like Clay and Stardust. In the background, the real show plays on the TV.

CLAY (O.S.)
What keeps our feet warm?

KWAN & KIDS (O.S.)
Socks!

CLAY (O.S.)
Gloves?

KWAN & KIDS (O.S.)
Socks! Socks! Socks!

CLAY (O.S.)
We've been on rocky planets, but
have we ever visited a socky one?

STARDUST (O.S.)
Twinkle, twinkle, twinkle!

Ray takes a bow for her brother. Ray clocks the camera.

RAY
Thanks for being my captive
audience. You did me a solid, bruh.

INT. REYES LIVING ROOM - DAY (2006)

Ray (9) has passed her cardboard rocket down to Kwan (4). She sits on the sofa behind him, focused on her rehearsal booklet for *A Christmas Carol*, scribbling notes.

On the TV, Clay (29) and Stardust sit on a tinfoil moon. Clay offers a bittersweet smile to the camera.

CLAY
When liquid becomes a gas, it
doesn't go away. It just spreads
out. It goes everywhere, like I am.

STARDUST
Twinkle, twinkle, twinkle...

CLAY
‘specially behind the stars...

KIDS (V.O.)
Aww...

Ray looks up, annoyed that Kwan is blocking her view.

RAY
Bruh. You wanna go blind?

KWAN
Like you’ll be, Tiny Trini?

RAY
Tiny Tim ain’t blind... Kwan, sit further away from the TV.

CLAY
It’s time to say goodbye...

KWAN
Clay is saying goodbye...

RAY
Then say it back, Kwan.

KIDS & KWAN
Goodbye...

The whimsical music fades into a single, lonely note.

CLAY
I must go home now. But you? You’re already home. Keep looking up because stars are us...

Clay boards Rocket. The ship blasts off into the cosmos. Stardust pulses with a final spark and vanishes.

The screen fades to black. The text appears: “Clay Goes Home.” A final production still of the team and studio follows: “Thank you for 7 years of *Stardust*.”

Ray drops her pen, finally giving the TV her full attention.

RAY
Wuh-No “See ya later, stardusters?”

Ray joins Kwan at the TV. A reflection of two small kids stare back in the glass. She looks down at her pen.

KWAN
Goodbye Clay...

RAY (CONT'D)
Hello Ray...

With sudden purpose, she opens the checkout card inside her booklet and crosses out "Trini Reyes." In its place, she writes RAY in bold letters. She holds it up to the camera.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. THEATRE BACKSTAGE - NIGHT (2025)

A CLIPBOARD displays the cast list for *Cat Scouts Live 2025*. A pen slides down to Trini "Ray" Reyes and checks a box: LATE.

Ray (29) bursts in, breathless and disheveled.

RAY
Sorry, sorry, sorry!

STAGE MANAGER
No more sorrys. Show up on time and you won't lose your head, eh?

RAY
(to camera)
I've lost my mind the moment I took my first steps on a theatre stage. What I had to gain was my heart...

INT. PUPPET ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

A CAT SCOUT PUPPET sits on a workbench with its head severed from its uniformed body. Ray stares at it, devastated.

RAY
...and a rough life...

A PUPPET MASTER inspects the damage, before shrugging.

PUPPET MASTER
Ruff ruff. Seems like a dog got to her. We're outta tape. Let me see what I can do. It'll take a while-

RAY
(to camera)
Should I wait for the puppet master or do it myself...? Do it myself!

Ray scans the nearby shelves, full of empty glue bottles.

RAY (CONT'D)
Do you see a bottle that's full of glue...? Here it is!

She grabs the full bottle that says FLAMMABLE.

INT. THEATRE STAGE - LATER

Tech rehearsal is a mess. The harsh lights expose the plywood of a half-finished forest set.

Ray stands with the other PUPPETEERS, dressed in a black stage suit. She holds her cat scout; the head is glued back on, but it looks more like a trauma patient than a scout.

STAGE MANAGER
Final tech. From top of “Meow-tain” song. Ray, keep that head steady.

Upbeat music track blares. Ray clumsily dances. As she twirls, centrifugal force pulls at the fresh glue.

CREAK. The glue snaps. Ray lunges for the head, but it's too late as it launches across the stage, landing on a spotlight.

HISS. SPARKS. The head transforms into a fireball. It rolls into the Colonel Calico puppet, which also goes up in flames.

PERFORMER
Fire! Colonel Calico is a fireball!

RAY
Cat Scouts? Now Cat Firefighters!

Ray grabs a fire extinguisher. She shakes it too hard that she loses grip of it. The extinguisher hits the flaming head and sends it flying into a puppet rack, engulfing everything.

PERFORMER
Please, not Sergeant Siamese!

RAY
The Siamese always rubbed me the wrong way...

The fire reaches the curtains, tripping a sensor. Sprinklers roar to life, slamming the stage with water. In seconds, the fire is out, but the puppets are floating charred lumps.

The music cuts. Drenched and holding her decapitated puppet, Ray looks up at the Stage Manager, who now holds an umbrella.

RAY (CONT’D)
Look on the bright side: fire’s out-

STAGE MANAGER
Only you. Only you could kill nine lives in *one fell swoop*.

RAY
Look at you quoting *Macbeth*...

STAGE MANAGER
Ugh, we should have raised the rate and hired Aurora! Take thy face hence! You're- You're-

RAY
On fire.

Ray points to a miniscule fire nearby. She gives a worried look to the camera.

END OF COLD OPEN

BEGIN MAIN TITLES

"Just a Phase" sung by River Matthews plays.

MONTAGE:

- Ray (29) and Kwan (24) board a cardboard rocket ship and blast off into a cardboard cosmos.

- MS. AURORA STARLING (29, Biracial, perfect) glides past them, looking flawless in a pristine cardboard spacesuit.

- Ray and Kwan's rocket crash lands on a strange world.

- On this new world, Clay (46) appears, dancing with Stardust and her axolotl sister, STARPOWER. River (50) pops out from behind Stardust and StarPower, while Skye (51) and Ylem (51) join them, surrounded by many other cosmic characters. They wave directly to the audience.

- The camera zooms out to reveal the previous scene is playing on a square TV. Ray and Kwan are perched on top of this TV, posing with their own Stardust-inspired puppets.

- The SOLID, LIQUID, AND GAS title graphic appears on the TV respectively above Clay, River, and Skye. Then expands out.

END MAIN TITLES

ACT ONE

INT. RAY'S CAR - DAY

Ray sees herself in the rearview mirror. She faces the camera.

RAY
What now, world? Should I go look for another job or should I...

Ray motions like she is slitting her own throat.

RAY (CONT'D)
...ll myself.

Awkwardly long pause.

RAY (CONT'D)
Whichhhhh one...? Apply myself or offffffff myself?

Ray sees her photo with Kwan (4) and herself (9) in front of a giant globe on the dashboard.

EXT. RAY'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

Ray drives away.

RAY (V.O.)
Alright, world. Perhaps, I should ask: What's next?

INT. RAY'S CAR - DAY (WEEKS LATER)

The car dissolves from empty to cardboard boxes crammed into the backseat, while a termination letter and an eviction notice sit shotgun.

Ray sits, with her hair like a bird's nest. She shifts into drive, weeping silently as she pulls away from the curb.

Her phone, mounted on the dash, PINGS. A notification banner slides across: MS. AURORA IS LIVE! (42K Watching).

Ray SWIPES away the notification. Her thumb accidentally hits a different video: BILLY CLAYTON DUBOIS (45), the original Clay, sits in a sunny garden wearing his iconic cosmic vest.

CLAY
Hey. You got a moment?

Ray reaches out to swipe him away, but her hand trembles and drops. She lets him speak.

CLAY (CONT'D)
Alright. You remember how when we were younger, we used to run around and hang out with Stardust and discover her stuff and ride Rocket and get lost on another planet and solve all the fun *clues*.

Ray sniffles, her eyes darting between the road and screen. On screen, Clay leans in with a smile as warm as a blanket.

CLAY (CONT'D)
But one day I said, "Guess what? Huge news: I'm returning to my home planet." And then Rocket took me away and we were gone. And we didn't see each other for like an eternity. Want to talk about that?

Ray reluctantly nods. She feels like a five-year-old again.

CLAY (CONT'D)
Fab. Because I realize it was sorta spontaneous. I just kinda took Rocket for a spin and went for a much needed vacation. And that was super challenging by the way. But great because I got to rest my head and take things slowly and now I'm literally doing all sorts of things that I dreamt of doing.

And then look at you and all you've done and all you've accomplished in all that time and it's just... it's just awesome, am I right?

Ray glances at the eviction notice. She snorts at the camera.

CLAY (CONT'D)
I mean, we started out with stuff and now it's what? Rent, and jobs, and families.

Ray aggressively flips a FAMILY PHOTO face down on the passenger seat, hiding the happy faces of her and her family.

CLAY (CONT'D)
And some of it has been kinda hard, you know? I know you know. And I hoped to tell you that I really couldn't have done all of that without your help.
(MORE)